

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action 2026 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Aidan Hill

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council, District 7

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including a San Pablo Specific Plan and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. San Pablo specific plan
- b. Zoning for housing in high-resource commercial areas like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave
- c. Extending 'middle housing' zoning to some parts of the Hills, while balancing fire risk
- d. Other strategies for Berkeley to affirmatively further fair housing

A. Housing Element view and implementation priorities

Berkeley must plan for 8,934 homes across income levels, and high-resource neighborhoods must accept a meaningful share. I support that obligation. Its success cannot be measured by zoning capacity alone. The measures that matter are homes completed, affordability at each income level, accessible and family-sized homes, tenants able to remain or return, small businesses retained, and public infrastructure delivered alongside growth.

The most important implementation lesson is that housing policy cannot stop at parcel-level zoning. Berkeley already requires project-specific construction and traffic plans and publishes separate information about permits, capital projects, street work, and traffic disruptions. I would integrate those tools at corridor scale. Before overlapping major projects proceed, the City should publish a shared construction calendar and require coordinated plans addressing accessible pedestrian routes, transit stops, loading and deliveries, emergency access, noise and dust, storefront access and visibility, utilities, drainage, public space, and street repair. A named coordinator should have authority to resolve conflicts quickly, with permit conditions and public reporting that make responsibility clear.

Telegraph shows what I would do differently. The Daily Californian reported that El Trompudo co-owner Eric Galindo said business fell roughly 50 percent after construction began next door, shortly after the restaurant opened. Moe's Books reflects a longer-running pressure. In 2022, owner Doris Moskowitz described the independent, family-owned, woman-owned bookstore as needing community support and warned separately that a major street redesign could threaten

the store if it ignored how customers bring in heavy used books. Together, these examples show why housing and business continuity must be planned together. New residents may strengthen local businesses after buildings open, while uncoordinated construction, sidewalk closures, and lost loading access can damage those same businesses first.

City departments, private builders, and UC Berkeley should coordinate before disruption begins rather than leaving each tenant or merchant to solve the combined impact alone.

B. Specific policies and fair-housing measures

a. San Pablo Avenue Specific Plan

On San Pablo Avenue, I support substantial mixed-use housing and a safer transit corridor. The plan also needs affordable rentals, ownership opportunities, and senior housing without repeating the displacement that earlier investment brought to lower-income residents, communities of color, and local businesses. That means enough capacity and predictable rules to make housing feasible, paired with on-site affordability, no net loss of protected homes, enforceable relocation and return rights, usable commercial space, accessible sidewalks and crossings, transit improvements, trees, shade, drainage, and a published infrastructure schedule.

b. High-resource commercial corridors

North Shattuck, Solano, and College Avenue present a particularly strong fair-housing case. These high-resource commercial areas have access to schools, jobs, services, and transit, yet have produced comparatively little housing. I support meaningful additional capacity there. I also hear the concern that broad upzoning can raise land values, destabilize leases, displace shops before construction begins, and replace small storefronts with spaces local businesses cannot afford. Merchants, residents, tenants, housing advocates, and builders should shape the plan before it is settled. The result should add homes on underused sites while retaining active shops, requiring on-site affordability, and setting objective transitions to adjacent homes. San Pablo and Southside should not absorb growth while other high-resource corridors remain largely unchanged.

Telegraph Avenue also belongs in the Housing Element discussion. It is both a transit-oriented housing corridor and a neighborhood whose businesses, public spaces, sidewalks, and cultural institutions make the housing useful. I support more homes on underused and redeveloped sites, including housing above commercial space, but the City must plan for the cumulative effect of many buildings and public projects arriving in the same few blocks.

c. Middle housing in the Hills and fire risk

Middle housing can open neighborhoods that historically excluded renters, younger residents, families, and multifamily homes. The current high-fire-hazard exclusion should remain until public modeling shows that added residents can evacuate safely. Any change must address Fire Department findings, emergency access, water reliability, home hardening, vegetation, and accessible evacuation. Fire cannot become a blanket excuse for exclusion where the evidence supports housing, and fair-housing language cannot dismiss a documented life-safety limit.

d. Other strategies to affirmatively further fair housing

My public-service record informs this approach. On Berkeley's Homeless Commission, I seconded and voted to send the Council a recommendation for administrative enforcement of

the City's source-of-income discrimination law. That work taught me that a legal protection has little value when residents cannot use it and no one is accountable for enforcement. The same principle applies to the Housing Element. When elected, I will strengthen source-of-income and fair-housing enforcement, eviction defense, disability access, replacement and return rights, tenant purchase opportunities, community land trusts, and the Small Sites Program. My first 100 days will include a public Housing Element dashboard and a cross-department implementation schedule naming the responsible agency, funding, deadline, and result for each major program. I hope Berkeley gains the homes it needs while existing residents and businesses remain, public infrastructure improves, and each neighborhood becomes more accessible and livable as it grows.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

I support Berkeley's goal of reducing greenhouse-gas emissions 80 percent below 2000 levels by 2050. The Climate Action Plan needs to operate as a funded delivery program rather than a collection of good intentions. Transportation and buildings are connected to housing, public health, affordability, disability access, and infrastructure. The budget and capital plan should show what each department will deliver, by when, and for whom.

For transportation, reducing car dependence means making the lower-emission choice useful: frequent and reliable buses, transit-priority signals and lanes, safe walking and bicycling routes, accessible stops, protected transfers, and street designs that work for people using wheelchairs, canes, strollers, and mobility devices. Curb management and enforcement should keep bus lanes, boarding areas, disability loading, deliveries, and bicycle facilities usable. Transportation implementation should include transit passes through major housing and institutional agreements, expanded access to Clipper START and EasyPass programs, and coordination with AC Transit and BART before land-use decisions are final rather than after residents arrive.

For buildings, the same standard applies to existing homes and new construction. My program would expand direct-install electrification, panel and wiring assistance, heat pumps, induction equipment, ventilation, filtration, and technical support for income-qualified households and multifamily buildings. Tenant protections, rent stability, trained workers, and adequate electrical capacity must be built into the program so climate upgrades do not become a new source of displacement. The federal ruling that caused Berkeley to repeal its new-construction gas ordinance removed one legal tool. It did not remove the City's responsibility. Berkeley can still

use lawful building standards, all-electric public capital projects, regional clean-appliance rules, incentives, City purchasing, financing, and public reporting.

Mitigation and resilience belong in one program. Berkeley needs clean backup power for homes, especially for low-income households, medically vulnerable residents, and multifamily buildings. Solar paired with battery storage can keep essential equipment operating during outages without relying on polluting generators. New construction and rehabilitation should use regenerative design: passive cooling, shade, healthy materials, water retention and reuse, living soil, habitat, and landscapes that reduce heat and flooding. Southside also needs clean-air rooms and emergency planning. My first budget cycle would include a public climate implementation table showing annual funding, responsible agencies, buildings retrofitted, household energy burden, transit reliability, vehicle miles traveled, mode share, tree survival, and pollution exposure. My contribution is an implementation discipline that joins climate targets to affordability and daily public health.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

I consider the June 24, 2025 mid-biennial budget vote the most important Council housing vote of the past four years. The Council faced a real general-fund deficit, but the adopted motion left \$1.1 million for the Small Sites Program instead of the \$3.9 million alternative and redirected approximately \$2.5 million in Measure U1 revenue that had been allocated to Small Sites. The budget resolution passed 5-3-1. I agree that the City had to close its deficit. I do not agree that a voter-approved affordable-housing revenue source and one of Berkeley's few anti-displacement acquisition tools should have been used as the pressure valve.

That decision matters because Berkeley's housing crisis is not only a shortage of future units. It is also the loss of homes that people can afford today. Middle housing and corridor zoning can expand capacity, but they do not let a nonprofit or community land trust acquire an occupied building when it comes on the market. Small Sites can preserve tenants in place, remove housing from speculation, rehabilitate unsafe conditions, and compound permanent affordability. The City's 2026 program now advertises \$3.8 million for acquisition and rehabilitation of 2-to-25-unit properties. That later increase is welcome, but it does not erase the governing lesson of the 2025 vote: preservation funding becomes unreliable when it is treated as a discretionary balance rather than housing infrastructure.

This focus is consistent with my earlier public service. On the Homeless Commission, I seconded and voted for a recommendation that the Council analyze stronger on-site inclusionary requirements, more inclusionary homes, geographic limits on fee payment, and access for extremely low-income residents. I later moved a recommendation reaffirming long-term housing subsidies as a high funding priority.

Had I been on the Council, I would have voted against the adopted budget motion and for the alternative that preserved the full Small Sites allocation. I would also have required staff to present separate, transparent options for the general fund and Marina shortfalls so residents

could see the tradeoff instead of having affordable-housing money disappear inside a larger budget package.

When elected, I will establish a recurring Small Sites appropriation, protect eligible Measure U1 housing revenue from unrelated operating gaps, and create a rapid acquisition pipeline with community land trusts and mission-driven nonprofits. That pipeline would fund predevelopment, appraisal, building-condition review, and rehabilitation planning before a property is lost to a faster buyer. Public reporting would show properties evaluated, offers made, acquisitions completed, tenants preserved, rehabilitation milestones, subsidy per home, and affordability terms. I support building more homes. This vote is my most important because it shows whether the City also has the discipline to preserve the homes and communities that already exist.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

I consider the July 2025 decision to vacate 381.23 feet of Carleton Street and convey the public right-of-way to Bayer Healthcare the most important environmental issue the Council faced in the past four years. The second reading passed with eight votes and one abstention. The City's stated purposes included reducing maintenance obligations and improving Bayer's circulation and security. Bayer also described fires and proposed a stormwater feature. Residents of the encampment and their advocates described the other side of the decision: public land would become corporate property, the street would close, and people living there would be displaced without the public first resolving where they could go.

I take the fire, smoke, sanitation, access, and stormwater concerns seriously. Those are legitimate public-health and environmental conditions. I reject the idea that the solution to a difficult public condition is to transfer the public realm to the adjacent corporation and allow privatization to substitute for governance. Public land, environmental infrastructure, and the lives of unhoused residents are not separate questions. A street can carry drainage, utilities, access, public space, and future transportation connections. Once the public surrenders it, those choices narrow permanently.

EPA records identify Bayer's Berkeley facility as a hazardous-waste reporter, and the environmental review anticipates investigation and remediation where soil, groundwater, or vapor contamination may affect development. Those records do not establish that every current operation is unsafe. They do establish an industrial site with hazardous-material responsibilities. Bayer is a private multinational corporation with a published human-rights policy, not a public-interest or human-rights institution. Berkeley should not reward it with public land without an exceptional and enforceable public benefit, especially when the transfer displaces residents and narrows future public choices.

Had I been on the Council, I would have voted no on the conveyance presented. I would have required a public alternative that addressed the immediate fire and sanitation hazards, provided toilets, waste service, outreach, storage, and an actual housing or sanctioned-site pathway,

retained the right-of-way, and secured stormwater and safety improvements through an easement or enforceable agreement. If Bayer sought an exclusive property benefit, I would have required a transparent valuation, a clear public-benefit analysis, permanent public protections, and an open comparison with retaining the land.

That alternative reflects work I have already done. On the Homeless Commission, I moved recommendations for a public-health study of unhoused residents and for the People's First Sanctuary approach, and the Commission later authorized me to present the sanctuary recommendation to the Council. That record joins sanitation, health, housing, and community-directed oversight instead of treating displacement as environmental remediation.

When elected, I will pursue voter approval before major public-land conversions, create a public land inventory, and require every proposed disposition to disclose its valuation, environmental function, public-access consequences, alternatives, beneficiary, and enforceable community benefit. The same program would build the public sanitation and stabilization infrastructure that prevents dangerous conditions from becoming a pretext for displacement. This is climate and environmental governance in its most concrete form: who controls land, who receives protection, who absorbs harm, and whether the public retains the capacity to meet future needs.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

Low-carbon living should be more convenient, reliable, and accessible than driving for a large share of daily trips. Housing near transit is necessary, but proximity on a map is not enough. A resident does not have meaningful transit access if the bus arrives once an hour, the stop has no seat or shelter, the ramp cannot deploy, the transfer is unsafe, or a broken sidewalk blocks the route.

Berkeley already has a Transit-First Policy Implementation Plan. The missing step is to implement it in land-use decisions. On corridors receiving additional housing, the City should coordinate early with AC Transit and BART; dedicate street space to bus reliability where evidence supports it; use signal priority and queue jumps; enforce bus and loading lanes; build accessible boarding areas; and require a continuous, step-free route to each major stop. Development agreements, transportation-demand programs, UC negotiations, and regional grants can support residential transit passes, secure bicycle parking, adaptive bicycles and shared mobility, car-share, delivery space, and real-time travel information. As a councilmember, I would use Berkeley's authority over streets, signals, curbs, sidewalks, capital funding, and land-use approvals while seeking service-frequency and operating-hour commitments through AC Transit.

This also extends an earlier public-service record. On the Homeless Commission, I moved and voted for a transportation recommendation that added a public shuttle option coordinated by

Berkeley and Alameda County. The lesson was the same: a route is useful only when the responsible agencies coordinate it around the people who need the service.

The completed Southside Complete Streets project is a starting point. Its bus lanes, signal priority, raised crossings, curb ramps, and protected cycletracks are the first segment of a network. The next step is to audit how those investments perform for disabled riders, repair the remaining access gaps, connect discontinuous routes, and publish bus travel time, reliability, ridership, conflicts, and accessible-stop coverage.

Tested international ideas can strengthen a Berkeley-scale program. Barcelona's green axes show how selected local streets can reduce through-driving while preserving access and coordinating with the bus network. Paris school streets use timed access, removable controls, and walking-speed service vehicles. Ljubljana uses graduated street types, defined delivery windows, and mobility support inside pedestrian-priority areas. Continuous-sidewalk projects provide level pedestrian paths and slower turning movements, while detectable boundaries and tactile warnings keep a visually seamless design from becoming dangerous for blind people.

Bowditch Commons is a practical place to coordinate this work. Berkeley already plans to reconstruct or heavily rehabilitate Bowditch from Bancroft to Dwight by December 2027. UC projects at Haste and Bowditch and at Channing and Bowditch would add roughly 3,000 student beds along the corridor, before counting residents of Unit 1 and Unit 2. The City should align the road project, UC housing, transit connections, accessible crossings, and public-space design before the pavement plan is fixed. A reversible pilot can test traffic diversion, emergency and disability access, deliveries, sanitation, bus delay, public use, and maintenance. This is coordinated design for the people who live there, not a decorative project imposed on the neighborhood.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets?

Pedestrian and cyclist safety is a system of street design, maintenance, disability access, and operations. I support Vision Zero and the 2026 Bicycle Plan, but adoption is not delivery. The Bicycle Plan itself makes implementation subject to funding and staffing. The highest-injury locations, school and campus approaches, transit connections, and missing low-stress links belong in a funded schedule with responsible departments and public completion dates.

The work begins with the whole trip. Every project should examine sidewalk condition, curb ramps, audible and vibrotactile signals, crossing time, lighting, visibility, bus boarding, bicycle conflicts, disability loading, construction detours, and maintenance. Raised side-street crossings and continuous sidewalks can slow turning vehicles where appropriate, with detectable boundaries, tactile warnings, and testing by blind and low-vision residents. Protected bicycle facilities, safer intersection geometry, daylighting, lower design speeds, and physical protection should replace overreliance on signs and education.

Bowditch Commons would coordinate a pedestrian-priority design with Berkeley's scheduled 2027 reconstruction and rehabilitation of Bowditch from Bancroft to Dwight. UC's planned housing at Haste and Bowditch and at Channing and Bowditch would add roughly 3,000 student beds along a corridor that already serves Unit 1 and Unit 2. The City should use that narrow construction window to design for the people who will live there, then test the design through a reversible pilot and advance permanent work only if the evidence supports it. Its operating plan should publish defined public-access hours, delivery and loading windows, overnight resident access, paratransit and disability loading, emergency and utility access, move-in procedures, sanitation service, bicycle movement, traffic-diversion controls, and responsibility for opening, closing, cleaning, and repair. The design should include continuous accessible routes, safer crossings, trees, shade, stormwater planting, seating, drinking water, bicycle parking, and connections to existing Southside bus and cycle facilities. Maintenance must be funded before opening because a beautiful project that cannot stay clean, accessible, and operational is unsuccessful public space.

Telegraph should remain multimodal while becoming safer and better maintained. The City deferred paving between Bancroft and Dwight while it considers the proposal titled "CAR FREE Telegraph." That title overstates the referral, which calls for studying limits on private-car access and includes bus service and loading. I would ask Public Works to return this badly deteriorated segment to a funded paving schedule and coordinate the work with the final corridor design so Berkeley does not pave twice. A design process should not become an indefinite maintenance delay.

Buses, people walking or using mobility devices, bicycles, deliveries, emergency access, and local businesses all depend on Telegraph. Defined plaza periods, better loading management, protected connections, accessible sidewalks, and transit priority can improve the corridor without an all-or-nothing promise before access and operations are solved. Bowditch provides the nearby place to test a stronger pedestrian-priority model without sacrificing Telegraph's transportation role.

Public reporting should show before-and-after speeds, serious collisions, near conflicts, crossing delay, accessible-route defects, repair time, bus performance, bicycle counts, loading compliance, and public-use measures. This approach combines ambition with accessibility, operations, testing, and maintenance.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

I support strong on-site inclusionary housing, and I oppose treating an in-lieu fee as a routine way to avoid it. Permanently affordable homes belong inside high-resource neighborhoods and inside the projects receiving the value of new zoning and public investment. Integration is not interchangeable with a payment. Berkeley's current program allows a 20 percent below-market-rate option, a full fee, or a combination. My policy would make on-site delivery the clear default and remove the full-fee path as an ordinary developer election.

This position predates the current campaign. On the Homeless Commission, I seconded and voted for a recommendation asking the Council to analyze stronger on-site inclusionary requirements, more inclusionary homes, geographic limits on fee payment, and access for extremely low-income residents and people experiencing homelessness.

I take the Turner Center's feasibility warning seriously. An inclusionary rule that makes every project financially impossible can produce neither market-rate nor affordable homes. I do not accept the leap from that warning to a general policy of letting projects buy out of integration. Before reducing on-site homes, the City should examine whether it can improve feasibility through adequate zoning capacity, predictable approvals, public or nonprofit land, lower-cost financing, targeted subsidy, standardized requirements, and a community-benefits agreement that assigns costs and responsibilities clearly. The assumptions and sensitivity analysis should be public so residents can see whether a claimed feasibility gap comes from land price, financing, construction cost, design, profit expectations, or the affordability requirement itself.

California law requires a rental inclusionary ordinance to provide alternative means of compliance, but it does not require Berkeley to make routine in-lieu fees the preferred alternative. Land dedication, off-site construction, and acquisition or rehabilitation should take priority when they can deliver an equal or better result. Any fee exception should be rare and require written public findings, an identified affordable-housing project with site control, committed financing, a delivery deadline, equivalent or greater affordable capacity, comparable access to schools, transit, and services, and protection against concentrating affordable homes in lower-income neighborhoods. Money collected should never be counted as housing produced.

Strong, lawful community-benefits agreements also belong in the City's toolkit when it has the authority and bargaining position to negotiate them. Each agreement should name the benefit, dollar amount, responsible party, completion date, reporting requirement, and remedy. Benefits can include additional affordable homes, accessible public space, affordable commercial space, workforce training, transit and street improvements, tree and stormwater infrastructure, and funded long-term maintenance. A community-benefits agreement should add to the baseline inclusionary obligation. Public documents must also distinguish a negotiated agreement from permit conditions constrained by state law.

My preservation strategy will operate alongside new-construction requirements. Berkeley's current Small Sites notice offers \$3.8 million for acquisition and rehabilitation of 2-to-25-unit properties with long-term affordability. My plan would make that program recurring and faster by funding nonprofit and community-land-trust capacity, appraisals, building-condition assessments, predevelopment, and rehabilitation planning before a sale closes. Public reporting

should cover properties reviewed, offers made, acquisitions completed, tenants preserved, rehabilitation status, and affordability terms.

The position is direct: build more homes, require integrated affordable homes, preserve occupied housing, and use public money and negotiated benefits to reach deeper affordability. Those goals carry real costs, and feasibility language cannot become a blank check to reproduce segregation.